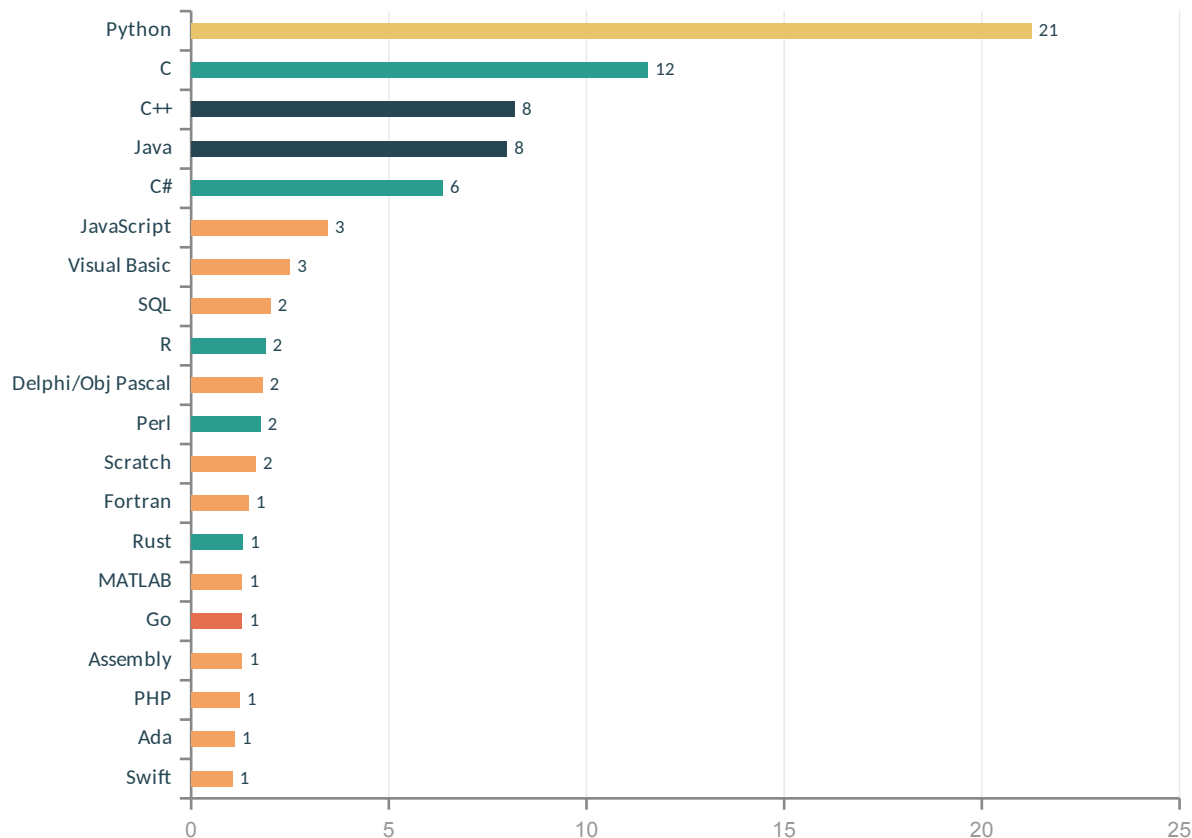


TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Python leads at 21.25% but posts the largest year-over-year decline among the top 5, while C surges to second and Go drops from 7th to 16th.

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain



Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index, March 2026

48.97%

of the total index held by the Top 4 languages

2X

Python's rating is more than double second-place C

+2.02 pp

C's year-over-year gain, the largest rise in the top 5

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

▲ RISING

Perl 24th → 11th **+13** +1.05 pp

R 16th → 9th **+7** +0.94 pp

Swift 26th → 20th **+6** +0.44 pp

C 4th → 2nd **+2** +2.02 pp

▼ FALLING

Go 7th → 16th **-9** -1.49 pp

C++ 2nd → 3rd **-1** -2.90 pp

Java 3rd → 4th **-1** -2.37 pp

Python 1st → 1st **0** -2.59 pp

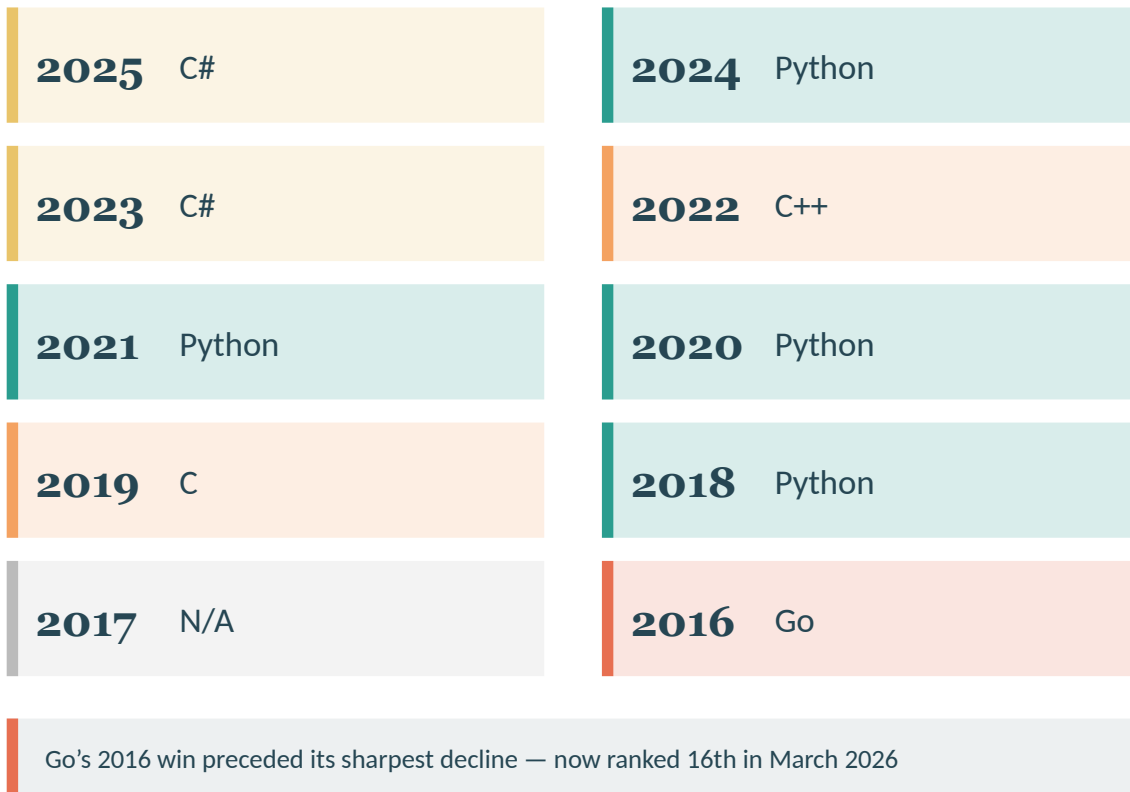
Go's drop from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp) is the sharpest fall — contrasting with its 2016 Language of the Year win

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

- 1 C is the only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points spanning four decades
- 2 Python rose from unranked (pre-1991) to #1 in approximately 25 years
- 3 Lisp fell from #2 in 1986 to #26 in 2026 — the most dramatic long-term decline

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language



The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

1 Python remains dominant but declining

At 21.25%, Python leads by a wide margin, yet its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest among the top 5. Monitor whether this signals a plateau or structural shift.

2 C's resurgence demands attention

C gained +2.02 pp and climbed to #2, likely driven by embedded systems, IoT, and performance-critical workloads. Ensure C expertise in your hiring pipeline.

3 Legacy languages are not dead

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7 ranks), and Fortran (still top 15) serve entrenched communities in scientific computing, data analysis, and infrastructure.

4 Go's sharp fall raises questions

Dropping from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp) — the largest decline of any top-20 language. Evaluate whether Rust (14th, +0.09 pp) is displacing Go for systems programming.

5 Concentration risk in the top 4

Python, C, C++, and Java hold 48.97% of the index. Diversifying language investments can reduce risk as the landscape shifts.